

→ to four-player multiplayer gaming through the same device. Enhanced speech recognition has been touted as one of the most important features of the next Kinect controller, including natural speech controls and speech-to-text. All indications are that this upcoming refresh will only up Kinect's ante, and who knows we may well glimpse upon the best motion controller among gaming consoles very soon.

The pretenders

Proof of the fact that the world of gaming has changed a lot, and why Sony and Microsoft's console refreshes have dragged on for too long, can be witnessed by two trends. Casual, mobile gaming is on the rise and people have grown past the idea of restrictive gaming tethered to a wired box and a television. While waiting for the next-generation of consoles we were all so used to, a few enterprising brains decided to cash in on the opportunity by offering gamers an alternative device with a unique experience. That's essentially how projects like OUYA, Valve's Steam Box, and Oculus Rift came into being – opportunistic and timely. And they're offering gamers the glimpse of a new, unexplored horizon. The current poster-child of the band of console rebels is the OUYA – a fully crowd-sourced, open-source, Android-powered game console – which is as small as a Rubik's cube and costs only \$99. It comes bundled with a controller and its own online store to purchase and download games from. It's still early days for the OUYA, and without a lineup of AAA titles the experience



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isn't stellar, it's what you'd get out of most Android games on a big screen. However, with time and iterative refinements, the device and its platform could offer indie developers and content providers a new avenue to explore – and for gamers, a new relatively inexpensive device to show off. Oculus Rift isn't as much a gaming console as it is an add-on accessory which would likely be bundled with consoles in the near future. Invented last year and demonstrated earlier this year at CES, the Oculus Rift – a virtual-reality head-mounted display unlike any other

– is on a mission to tap into your peripheral vision and take game immersiveness to a whole new level. It has been endorsed by several gaming industry veterans, and early reports of the device are

extremely encouraging. Perhaps the most hotly anticipated new gaming console, among PC fans, has to be the Valve Steam Box. Based on Linux and sporting PC-like hardware, Gabe Newell, CEO of Valve – the good folk who manage Steam, a cross-platform cloud-gaming solution for PC gamers – wants to offer the Steam Box as an extension of Steam. The plan is to manufacture a blueprint device, known internally as Bigfoot, and allow third-party manufacturers to design and sell their own Steam Boxes. These dedicated gaming devices will come with controllers and screencasting solutions for an effortless transition between screens while gaming. An interesting feature of the Steam Box, which is still under production, is to embed biometric sensors within its controller to measure and detect a gamer's heartbeat, for example, and finetune a game's performance based on a gamer's immersion levels. Newell describes this aspect of the Steam Box absolutely crucial to provide gamers different experiences while playing the same game. 



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